centric but intended for administrators in other parts of the empire as well.[53] This may well be so, and the Separate Edicts at Sannathi suggest it. All the same, at Kalinga the instruction will have carried a meaning more loaded by recent events and the remembrance of them.

Those parts of Ashoka's message that are found at Dhauli and Jaugada are neither about the preaching nor the practice of dhamma. They are centrally concerned with delivering better administration in a politically sensitive province. The emperor modifies the content and tenor of his message keeping in mind the situation on the ground.

At one level, it seems a truism to say that because reception within specific contexts mediates messages and colours interpretations, uniformity of meaning across landscapes is a myth. In the peculiar case of Ashoka's edicts, which despite being spread over thousands of kilometres tend very strongly to be seen as disseminating a single message, it has seemed worthwhile to me to scrutinize the truth content of this truism. The valorization of Ashoka by Buddhist historiography is understandable, yet it cannot be denied that the religious agenda driving such history has helped immensely to reinforce the idea that Ashoka's messages can be reduced to a singular sermon in defence of the faith. By contrast, because the ways in which political authority is inscribed in a landscape are necessarily varied, attentiveness to situational variety is necessary. Some regions are conquered by the sword and require healing; others need pacification; yet others may respond best if addressed in Greek and Aramaic. Landscape, in relation to Ashoka's edicts, is not a *tabula rasa* on which nothing other than contrition and a new moral agenda, bordering on missionary zeal, are written. Local history offers possibilities sometimes invisible.

As one anguished king pointed out to his companion in a very different context: 'There are more things in heaven and earth, Horatio/Than are dreamt of in your philosophy.'